

The Boston Globe

Serving our community since 1872

WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 26, 2026

DOLLY PARTON
1946-2026



JACK PLUNKETT/INVISION/AP/FILE 2012

Dolly Parton viewed herself, first and foremost, as a songwriter.

A dazzling star who always got last laugh

By Bill Friskies-Warren
NEW YORK TIMES

Dolly Parton, a rhinestone-studded, rags-to-riches daughter of Appalachia who for six decades ruled country music — and much of pop culture — with an outsize personality and down-home wit that enshrined her as one of America’s most cherished originals, died Tuesday in Nashville. She was 80.

Her death was announced in a video posted on social media by her nephew Bryan Seaver. A spokesperson said she died after a brief battle with cancer. Concerns about Ms. Parton’s health, which began last year as she postponed and later canceled a Las Vegas residency, grew to the point that she took to social media last fall to announce, “I ain’t dead yet.” In May, she said she had responded well to treatment after, as she put it, her immune and digestive systems “got all out of whack” in recent years.

From her hardscabble beginnings to glittering stardom, Ms. Parton’s life was the stuff of make-believe.

With her voluptuous figure, sparkly stage costumes, and blonde bouffant wigs, she was likened by writer Chet Flippo to the Big Rock Candy Mountain, the Depression-era symbol of abundance.

PARTON, Page A10

We will always love her

By Christopher Muther
GLOBE STAFF

In 1978, everything, everywhere, was dripping disco and lit by mirrored balls. Andy Gibb and his brothers, the Bee

APPRECIATION

Gees, dominated the charts, along with anything from the “Grease” soundtrack. Those country artists who managed to shoe-horn themselves into the Billboard Top 100 — such as Kenny Rogers with “The Gambler” — stuck to their twangy formula.

And then there was Dolly Parton. Never afraid to reinvent herself, laugh at herself, or simply join the party and have a bit of fun, Parton burst onto the dance floor with a disco song; yes, Dolly did disco. “(Baby) I’m Burning” was a lesson in fearlessness. The woman who, culturally speaking, grew up about as far from New York City and Studio 54 as possible arrived in a scarlet chiffon dress, took a spin around the dance floor, had a laugh, and scored a hit.

There’s a term for a musician who is able to hop from one genre to another. They’re called a crossover artist, and Parton was the ultimate crossover artist, not just musically, but anywhere else she decided to place one of her long red fin-

APPRECIATION, Page A10



1 in 4 former NFL players had CTE at the time of death, a new study finds

Football takes a big hit



DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

Many Patriots players wear Guardian caps, which are believed by some to be safer for practices with contact.

A quarter of ex-NFL players’ deaths tied to CTE, bringing warnings for young, old

By Allyson Chiu
and Matt Porter
GLOBE STAFF

Head trauma has increasingly become an existential question for football. But just how common brain damage is among players was an open question until Tuesday, when an alarming newly published study found that one quarter of former NFL players who died over a recent six-year period had the neurodegen-

erative disease known as CTE.

And the numbers of chronic traumatic encephalopathy, the authors added, could be much higher, since their results are based on examining only those deceased players whose brains were donated for research.

The study, conducted by experts at Mass General Brigham, Boston University, and the Concussion & CTE Foundation, highlights the safety issues in a popu-

lar sport played by scores of college athletes — and the roughly 17,000 high school students in Massachusetts who began a new season of football practices on Monday.

“These [NFL] athletes didn’t just get their head impact exposure at the professional level,” said Dr. Daniel Daneshvar, the study’s lead author and chair of physical medicine and rehabilitation at MGB. “They got exposed

to head impacts at the collegiate level, at the high school level, and in many cases, the youth level. All of those hits accumulated to increase their risk of having this pathology in their brain.”

Daneshvar called the findings a “wake-up call.”

Among the general population, CTE affects less than 1 percent of people. Based on the results of the study, then, on a 53-

CTE, Page A7



JONATHAN WIGGS/GLOBE STAFF

Supporters of Evan MacKay, a democratic socialist, gathered in Cambridge earlier in the month.

In Mass., hoping Mamdani rubs off

Some candidates for state office see groundswell

By Samantha J. Gross
GLOBE STAFF

Under a blazing sun, more than 200 volunteers gathered in a park on a recent Saturday, ready to knock on doors. Some wore blue “Zohran Mamdani” campaign T-shirts or New York City Democratic Socialists

merch.

Claire Valdez, one of New York’s most prominent democratic socialists and the first elected official to publicly back the New York City mayor, sought to fire up the crowd.

Mamdani’s election, she said, proved that “this movement is not restricted to one city or one state.”

That was apt messaging, because this wasn’t Sunnyside, Queens, mind you, or Bushwick, Brooklyn. Valdez spoke from a

grassy lawn on the Cambridge Common, and the progressive Democrats there hoped she was addressing the next crest in a Mamdani-fueled blue wave.

“There is just a real profound sense of optimism and a way in which Zohran’s race turned to ordinary people as a source of that strength,” said Evan MacKay, a Cambridge Democrat who is challenging a sitting state representative for the second time and for whom Valdez and others

MAMDANI, Page A6

‘It really emerged that alpha-gal syndrome and the lone star tick problem was something that people were really worried about.’

CLAIRE SEGUIN, *president, chief operating officer of Martha’s Vineyard Hospital*

Study aims to uncover secrets of tick-borne syndrome

By Allyson Chiu
GLOBE STAFF

Researchers are launching what they say is a first-of-its-kind study of alpha-gal syndrome on Martha’s Vineyard to better understand the potentially deadly tick-borne allergy.

Martha’s Vineyard Hospital, a member of Mass General Brigham, will follow residents of the island who’ve been bitten by a lone star tick with the goal of identifying who develops the allergy and why. Researchers plan to track up to 300 participants over two years to examine how often the allergy occurs in those who are bitten, which factors may increase risk, and how people’s immune systems might change over time.

“Alpha-gal syndrome is an emerging health concern in our region, but there are still many unanswered questions about why some people develop the condition after a tick bite while others do not,” Dr. Jacob Lemieux, an infectious disease expert at MGB who is leading the study, said in a statement. “By following participants over time, we hope to better understand the biological and environmental factors that influence risk and generate information that can help guide future diagnosis, prevention and patient care.”

Alpha-gal syndrome, an allergy to a sugar molecule present in red meat and dairy products, has received widespread attention amid

ALPHA GAL, Page A7

For breaking news, updated stories, and more, visit our website:

BostonGlobe.com

VOL. 310, NO. 57

*

Suggested retail price
\$4.00



To beach or not to beach

Wednesday: Sunny, pleasant. High 78-83. Low 64-69.

Thursday: Humidity’s back. High 80-85. Low 66-71.

High tide: 10:59 a.m., 11:05 p.m.

Sunrise: 6:03 Sunset: 7:28

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

ICE arrested nearly 50,000 people in July, the highest single monthly arrest total during the second Trump administration. **A2.**

Canada announced retaliatory tariffs as high as 50 percent on hundreds of American products after the collapse of trade talks. **B5.**



Summer isn’t over yet but it’s time to start savoring gelato and tacos (and much more). **G1.**

BSO musicians and management agreed to a three-year deal after months of negotiations. **B1.**